

What are Custom ROMs?

Custom ROMs are developed by third party developers as the core firmware of their targeted devices. Android being open source, is a logical choice for many such ROMs being released. Custom ROMs present their own set of advantages and disadvantages: you get a plethora of choices, all with their own themes and features, constantly being updated, and giving you options to exploit your device, doing whatever you want to do with it. However, they're not perfect and are susceptible to bugs. All custom firmwares aren't free from bugs and still require exhaustive testing. So there's a chance you may not quite get the performance boost you're looking for, or even if you do, it might be a bumpy ride. ROMs also require your device to be rooted, and though no longer illegal, the risks are still the same.

Custom ROMs based off of Android often bring the advantage of newer OS versions to devices that might not otherwise receive them through proper vendors. Ice Cream Sandwich, anyone?. CyanogenMod isn't the only custom firmware based on the Android architecture, although it is a sort of a torchbearer for the movement. Replicant is another one, built around the purpose of replacing the bundled hardware drivers with open source drivers. This was built with the intent of making it easier to share firmwares that actually work (since the drivers shipped with the phone are proprietary and not free). It even has its own market called F-Droid for applications.

How does one go about exactly installing a custom ROM on their mobile device? It usually varies for different manufacturers, but the basic steps are the same. We'll take the example of CyanogenMod, but whatever you're

using, you need to take a backup of your current ROM, including apps and data. The process is similar to flashing your firmware, with a few more steps.

